Online Safety

INTRODUCTIUON TO E-Safety & Data Privacy

What is E-Safety?

E-Safety is defined as the safe, responsible, and ethical use of modern technology. This encompasses the internet, mobile communications (text messaging, instant messaging applications), online gaming platforms, electronic mail, and smart connected devices. It's not just about the "common sense" stuff – there's a whole lot more to E-Safety which in today's world has become an ever-increasing concern to internet users.

In short, E-safety is often defined as the safe and responsible use of technology.

This includes the use of the internet and also other means of communication using electronic media (eg text messages, gaming devices, email etc)

TASK

Carefully evaluate each item of information listed below. Place a checkmark (✓) in the correct risk category and provide a brief explanation justifying why that specific data item presents a safety risk if exposed online.

Data Item	High Risk	Low Risk	Security Risk Explanation
Home Postcode & Address			Allows strangers to identify your exact physical residence.
Photo in ERGS School Uniform			
Mobile Telephone Number			
Favourite Video Game Genre			
Date of Birth & Full Name			
Live Geotagged Status Update			

Research shows that 52% of 8-17 year olds report someone sharing a photo/video of them without asking permission. Why is asking for consent before posting photos of peers an essential component of digital etiquette?

Online Gaming Safeguards

Online gaming allows real-time multiplayer interactions across the world. Statistics indicate that **91% of young people participate in online gaming**, with popular titles such as *Fortnite* recording high user engagement (where 68.8% of players purchase in-game content, spending an average of 6 to 10 hours weekly).

While gaming provides collaborative enjoyment, key risks include:

- **Unfiltered Communication:** Voice chat headsets and text boxes can expose young players to vulgar language, harassment, and abusive conduct.
- **Anonymity & False Personas:** Gamers met online are digital strangers. Players must never disclose personal details or agree to meet gaming contacts outside the game environment.
- **Griefing & Cyberbullying:** 'Griefing' occurs when players deliberately destabilise another user's game experience through targeted harassment or cheating.
- **Financial Exploitation:** In-game microtransactions and pop-up purchases can quickly accumulate substantial unexpected charges. Setting devices to restricted purchasing modes or offline modes prevents accidental billing.

Cyber Security & Malware Threats When Downloading

Downloading software, audio, or video files from unverified online channels exposes computer networks to severe security vulnerabilities and legal repercussions.

Threat Name	Technical Definition & Impact
Computer Virus	A malicious code sequence that attaches to legitimate programs, replicating itself across storage systems and corrupting or deleting user files.
Trojan Horse	Malicious software disguised as genuine, desirable software (e.g., a free game mod or movie download) that secretly creates backdoors for unauthorized access.
Spyware & Keyloggers	Software covertly installed to monitor user behaviour, record keystrokes, and harvest login credentials, passwords, and banking details.
Phishing	Fraudulent communications (emails, messages) mimicking official bodies (banks, schools) designed to trick users into revealing sensitive security data.
Pharming	A sophisticated exploit that redirects web traffic from legitimate websites to fraudulent replica sites without user knowledge, capturing user credentials.

Social Media

The standard minimum age requirement for registering accounts on major social media platforms (including Facebook, Instagram, X/Twitter, Snapchat, and TikTok) is 13 years old. These platforms offer instant messaging, content sharing, and live broadcasting features.

Critical Settings every user must manage include:

Privacy Settings | Location Services | Tag Approvals

Your Digital Footprint

A **Digital Footprint** is the permanent, cumulative trail of data left behind by all online interactions, comments, photo uploads, searches, and social messaging. Once content is transmitted electronically, control over that data is lost.

Cyberbullying & Trolling

Cyberbullying refers to the deliberate, repeated use of digital communications to harass, intimidate, humiliate, or isolate an individual. Unlike traditional bullying, cyberbullying can occur 24/7, penetrate home environments, and reach vast audiences instantly.

Common forms include:

- Harassment & Stalking: Repeated sending of offensive, threatening, or unwanted messages.
- Defamation & Exclusion: Spreading malicious rumours, creating false accounts, or intentionally excluding individuals from group chats.
- Identity Theft & Impersonation: Hacking into personal profiles to post inflammatory material under another pupil's name.
- Trolling: Deliberately posting provocative, abusive, or offensive comments online to disrupt discussions and cause emotional distress.

Online Grooming: Awareness & Prevention

Online Grooming is a process where an individual establishes an emotional connection with a young person to lower their inhibitions and exploit them. Perpetrators frequently create fake online profiles, pretend to share identical hobbies, offer digital gifts or game currency, and offer excessive praise to build trust.

Groomers often seek to transition conversations from open platforms to private messaging, obtain explicit photographs, or arrange secret real-world meetings. Crucial Principle: Adults with bad intentions can easily fake digital identities.

Never agree to meet an online contact in person

Safeguarding Protocol

If you encounter disturbing content, harassment, or uncomfortable contact online, execute the following protocol immediately:

1. DO NOT DELETE THE MESSAGES: Preserve all text transcripts, images, emails, and timestamped screenshots. These constitute essential forensic evidence required by police and school authorities to trace digital footprints (including IP addresses).

2. DO NOT REPLY OR RETALIATE: Engaging with bullies or trolls escalates the situation and can complicate investigation efforts.

3. TELL A TRUSTED ADULT IMMEDIATELY: Inform your Form Tutor, Head of Year, Designated Teacher for Child Protection, parent, or guardian.

4. UTILISE OFFICIAL REPORTING CHANNELS: Report incidents directly to **CEOP** (Child Exploitation and Online Protection Command) via their official reporting button, or contact **Childline** (0800 1111).